

Are You the Chicken or the Eagle?

A poem by Charles Osgood

The Beginning

A man once found an eagle's egg and put it in the nest of a barnyard chicken. The eagle hatched and grew up with the rest of a brood of chicks — and thought he didn't look at all the same.

Living as a Chicken

He scratched the earth for worms and bugs and played a chicken's game. The eagle clucked and cackled, he made a chicken's sound. He thrashed his wings, but only flew a few feet off the ground. *"That's high as chickens fly,"* the eagle had been told.

The Moment of Wonder

The years passed, and one day when the eagle was quite old, he saw something magnificent flying very high — making great majestic circles up there in the sky. He'd never seen the likes of it. **"What's that?"** he asked in awe, watching in wonder and amazement at the grace and beauty that he saw.

The Tragic Answer

"Why, that's an eagle," someone said. *"He belongs up there, it's clear. Just as we — since we are chickens — belong earthbound down here."*



The Chicken Mindset

Stays grounded. Accepts limits set by others. Flies only as high as those around them say is possible.

The Eagle Nature

Born for the sky. Capable of majestic heights. Needs only to *believe* in what it truly is.

The Choice

You are not defined by the nest you were raised in. **Recognize your true nature — and rise.**



Storytelling That Sells

How Sales Professionals Use Stories to Build Trust and Drive Action

In this course, you will learn how to transform the way you sell — not by pushing harder, but by connecting deeper.



Turn Facts Into Stories

Make product details memorable



Use Stories Everywhere

Discovery, objections, and closing



Build Real Trust

Make customers feel understood



Drive Better Results

Improve conversations without sounding pushy

Why Stories Sell

People Remember Stories Better Than Facts

Buyers Forget

- Product features
- Long explanations
- Generic claims
- Complex data

Buyers Remember

- Real customer examples
- Clear before-and-after outcomes
- Relatable problems
- Emotional turning points

✓ **Key Idea:** Stories make value easier to understand. When a buyer can picture themselves in a story, they are far more likely to act.

The Problem With Feature Selling

Features Tell. Stories Show.

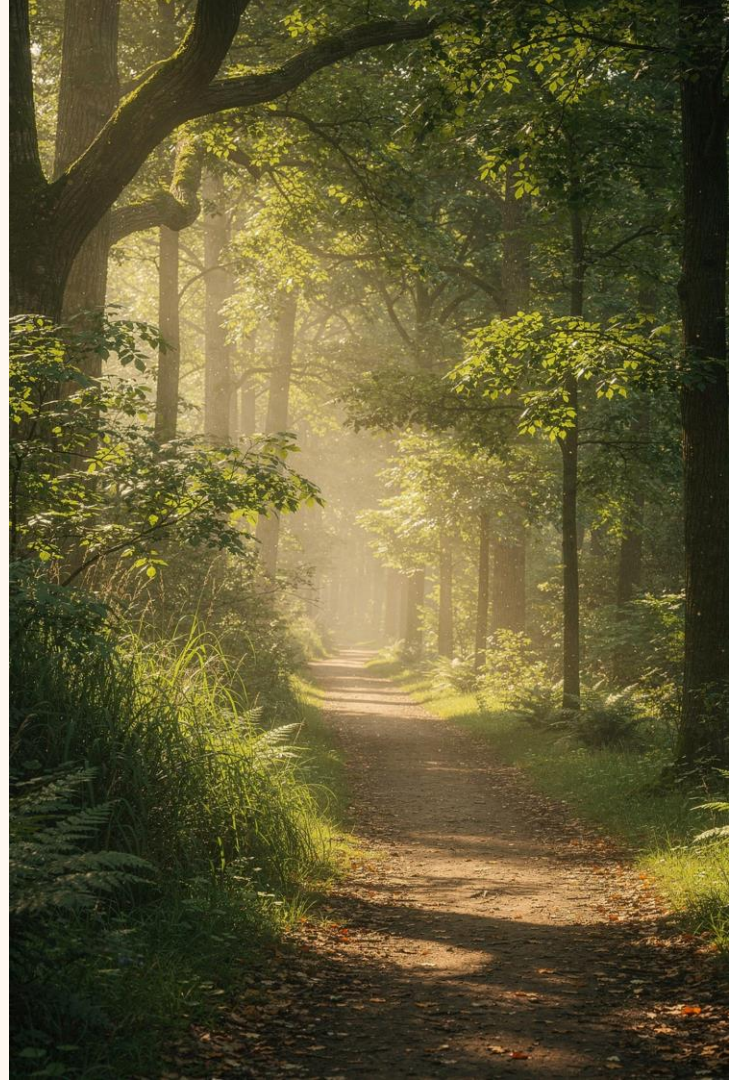
FEATURE-BASED SELLING

"Our service includes 24/7 support, onboarding, reporting, and account management."

STORY-BASED SELLING

"One client came to us after losing three major customers because their service team was overwhelmed. Within 90 days, they had a clearer support process, faster response times, and better customer retention."

 **Sales Lesson:** Facts explain *what* you offer. Stories explain *why it matters*.



What Makes a Sales Story Work?

A Strong Sales Story Has 5 Parts

-  **Customer Situation**
Set the scene — who is the customer and what is their world like?
-  **Problem or Challenge**
What pain or obstacle were they facing before your solution?
-  **Turning Point**
The moment they decided something had to change.
-  **Solution**
How your product or service helped them move forward.
-  **Measurable Result**
The concrete outcome — numbers, time saved, growth achieved.

 **Simple Story Formula:** "Before working with us, the client struggled with _____. After we helped them _____, they achieved _____."

Sales Storytelling Is Not Entertainment

The Goal Is Business Clarity

A great sales story is not about impressing the buyer — it is about helping them see clearly. Every story you tell should serve a specific business purpose.

Understand the Problem

The buyer recognizes their own challenge in your story.

See Themselves in the Situation

They connect emotionally with the customer in your story.

Believe Change Is Possible

The story shows a realistic path from problem to solution.

Trust Your Approach

Your solution-oriented framing builds credibility.

Feel Safer Moving Forward

Reduced hesitation leads to better buying decisions.



Key Rule: The buyer should always be the hero of the story — not your company.

The Buyer as the Hero

Do Not Make Your Company the Hero

WEAK STORY FOCUS

"We are amazing. Our product is powerful. Our team is the best."

This approach centers your company and leaves the buyer feeling like a passive observer — not an active decision-maker.

STRONG STORY FOCUS

"The client faced a difficult challenge, made a smart decision, and achieved a better outcome."

This approach puts the buyer in the driver's seat and positions your company as the trusted guide alongside them.

**THE HERO
(THE CUSTOMER):
FACES THE
CHALLENGE,
MAKES THE
DECISION,
ACHIEVES THE
OUTCOME**



They embark on a journey
towards a better future

THEY OWN THE SUCCESS

**THE GUIDE
(YOUR COMPANY):
PROVIDES TOOLS,
EXPERTISE, AND
SUPPORT TO HELP
THE SUCCEED**



We illuminate the path
and remove obstacles

WE SUPPORT THEIR VICTORY

Where Stories Fit in the Sales Process

Use Stories Throughout the Sales Conversation

Stories are not just for closing. The right story at the right moment can reduce buyer hesitation at every stage of the journey.



Key Idea: The right story at the right moment can reduce buyer hesitation and accelerate decisions.



Example: Prospecting Story

Use a Story to Earn Attention

STANDARD OUTREACH

"We help companies improve employee training."

Generic. Forgettable. No emotional hook. The buyer has heard this a hundred times before.

STORY-BASED OUTREACH

"We recently helped a service company reduce new-hire ramp-up time after managers struggled to train people consistently across locations."

Specific. Relatable. Immediately shows you understand real business problems.



AI Prompt Example: "Act as a consultative sales expert. Create a short prospecting story for a company that helps clients improve employee training. Keep it under 80 words."

Case Study: The Forgotten Value

How One Sales Rep Changed Their Approach and Changed Their Results



Situation

Rep explained features; prospects silent



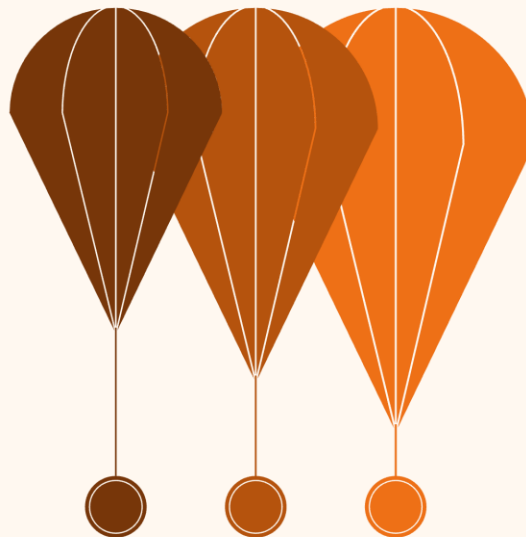
Change

Rep shared short customer stories



Result

Better questions and focused meetings



This case study illustrates a simple but powerful truth: when you stop selling features and start sharing stories, buyers lean in. They ask better questions, they stay engaged longer, and they move through the sales process with greater confidence.

The Client's Problem

Lead with the challenge the customer was facing — not your product specs.

The Business Impact

Show what was at stake — revenue lost, time wasted, customers leaving.

The Outcome Achieved

Close with a concrete, measurable result that the buyer can picture for themselves.

Reflection Exercise

Think About Your Own Sales Conversations

The best sales storytellers are not born — they are built through deliberate practice and honest self-reflection. Use these questions to audit your current approach.

1

Facts or Stories?

Do you rely more on facts or stories when explaining your value to a prospect?

2

Your Go-To Story

What customer success story do you already tell? Is it structured around the 5-part formula?

3

Where Buyers Get Lost

Where do prospects usually get confused or disengage in your conversations?

4

Your Clarity Story

What story could make your value easier to understand for your most common buyer type?

 **AI Prompt:** "Help me identify 3 customer stories I could use in sales conversations based on the services I provide."

The Sales Story Framework

Slide 11

S.T.O.R.Y. MODEL

A powerful framework for crafting sales stories that resonate, persuade, and drive action — one letter at a time.

1

S — Situation

What was happening?

2

T — Trouble

What problem created pressure?

3

O — Opportunity

What changed or became possible?

4

R — Resolution

What solution was implemented?

5

Y — Yield

What result was achieved?

Step 1: Situation

Slide 12

 START HERE

The buyer needs to **recognize the situation quickly**. A relatable context pulls them into the story before you've even made your pitch.

Good Situation Starters

- "A company similar to yours was dealing with..."
- "One client came to us after struggling with..."
- "A team we worked with was trying to improve..."

AI Prompt to Try

-  "Create 5 situation starters for a sales story about helping companies improve customer retention."

Use AI to rapidly generate opening lines tailored to your specific industry or buyer persona.



Step 2: Trouble

Slide 13

The trouble is what **creates interest**. Without a clear problem, there is no story — and no reason for the buyer to keep listening.

Common Sales Trouble Examples



Lost Time



Low Retention



Poor Communication



Missed Revenue



Confused Customers



Slow Onboarding



Inconsistent Performance

AI Prompt to Try



"List 10 business problems that would make a company interested in leadership development services."

Use this prompt to map common pain points to your specific offering and tailor your trouble statement to each buyer.



Step 3: Opportunity

Slide 14

THE TURNING POINT

The opportunity is the **pivot in the story** — the moment when the buyer sees that change is possible. It shifts the narrative from problem to possibility.

"They realized the issue was not effort. Their team was working hard. The real issue was that everyone followed a different process."

What Makes a Strong Opportunity Statement?

- It reframes the problem — not lack of effort, but lack of alignment
- It creates a moment of recognition for the buyer
- It opens the door to your solution naturally

AI Prompt to Try

 "Turn this customer problem into a turning point: Our client had inconsistent sales follow-up and was losing deals."

AI can help you reframe any problem into a compelling opportunity statement that resonates with your buyer.

Step 4: Resolution

Slide 15

Explain the solution simply. **Avoid a long product pitch.** The resolution should feel like a natural answer to the opportunity — not a feature list.

1 ✗ Weak Resolution

"We implemented our full-featured platform with advanced analytics and integrated dashboards."

This is product-centered, jargon-heavy, and forgettable.

2 ✓ Strong Resolution

"We helped them create one simple follow-up system so every lead received the right message at the right time."

This is client-centered, clear, and easy to repeat.

 AI Prompt: "Rewrite this solution explanation so it is simple, client-focused, and easy to understand."

Step 5: Yield

Slide 16

END WITH A RESULT

A story feels stronger when it has a **clear outcome**. The yield gives the buyer proof that the resolution worked — and a vision of what's possible for them.

30%

Onboarding Time

Reduced onboarding time by 30%



Client Retention

Improved client retention rates



Sales Cycle

Shortened the sales cycle



Response Rates

Increased response rates



Complaints

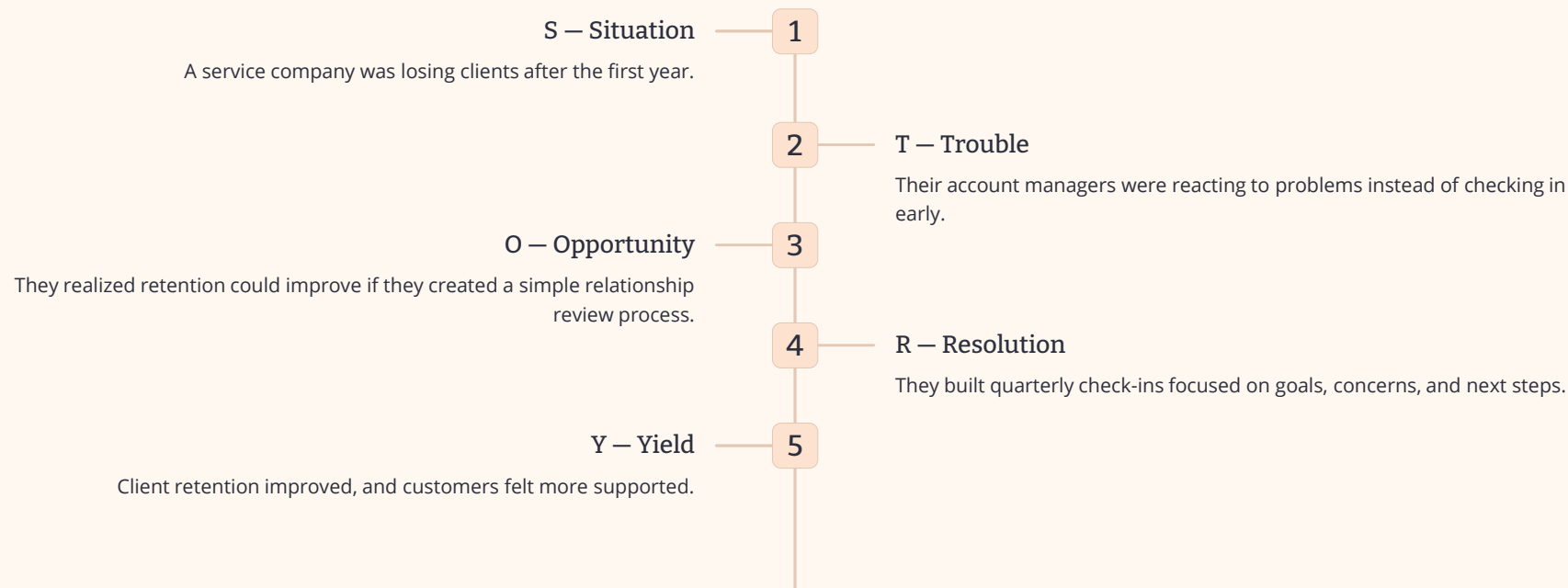
Reduced customer complaints

 AI Prompt: "Create 5 ways to describe a sales outcome when exact numbers are not available."

Story Example: Full S.T.O.R.Y. Model

Slide 17

See how all five elements come together in a single, cohesive sales story that is short, clear, and customer-centered.



✓ This story is under 60 words, entirely customer-centered, and easy for any salesperson to repeat from memory.

Turning Data Into a Story

Slide 18

Data alone is not enough. Numbers without context are forgettable. Wrapping data in a story makes it meaningful — and memorable.

Data Statement

"Our system improves response time by 40%."

This is accurate — but it doesn't create an emotional connection or help the buyer visualize the impact.

Story Version

"One client had customers waiting too long for answers. After using our system, they responded faster, reduced frustration, and improved the customer experience."

This version puts the buyer at the center and makes the result feel real and relatable.

 AI Prompt: "Turn this sales statistic into a short customer-centered story: Our service reduced response time by 40%."



Interactive Exercise

Slide 19

BUILD YOUR FIRST SALES STORY

Use this fill-in-the-blank structure to draft your own sales story using the S.T.O.R.Y. model. Complete each line with a real client example from your experience.

01

Situation

A client was struggling with ____.

02

Trouble

The problem caused ____.

03

Opportunity

They realized ____.

04

Resolution

We helped them ____.

05

Yield

As a result, they ____.

 AI Prompt: "Interview me one question at a time and help me build a short sales story using the S.T.O.R.Y. model."

Evaluation Checkpoint

Slide 20

Before you use your story in a real sales conversation, run it through this checklist. A strong sales story should pass every test.

Your Story Quality Checklist

Short

Can be told in under 90 seconds without losing impact.

Clear

Anyone can follow it — no jargon, no confusion.

Customer-Centered

The client is the hero, not your product.

Business-Focused

Tied to a real business outcome the buyer cares about.

Easy to Repeat

Your whole team can tell it consistently.

Connected to a Real Buyer Need

Speaks directly to a challenge your buyer recognizes.



AI Prompt: "Review this sales story and improve it. Make it shorter, more persuasive, and more customer-centered."

Use AI as your editor — paste your draft story and let it help you sharpen every element before your next sales conversation.

Stories During Discovery

SLIDE 21

Use Stories to Open Better Conversations

A short story can help buyers share more openly — unlocking insights that direct questions rarely surface.

"Another client initially thought their issue was low sales activity, but discovery showed the real issue was weak follow-up consistency. Is anything like that happening here?"



AI Prompt: "Create 3 short discovery stories that help a buyer talk about hidden business problems."



SLIDE 22

Stories for Objection Handling

Stories Reduce Defensiveness

Instead of arguing with a buyer's objection, tell a relevant story that lets them arrive at the insight themselves.

Price Objection Example

"I understand. Another client had the same concern. They first looked only at cost, but later realized the larger cost was losing customers because their process was inconsistent."

Why Stories Work Here

- Removes the adversarial dynamic
- Lets the buyer draw their own conclusion
- Reframes cost as risk, not price
- Builds empathy through shared experience



AI Prompt: "Create 3 consultative story responses to the objection: Your solution is too expensive."

Stories for Urgency

Help Buyers See the Cost of Waiting

Urgency should come from the business problem, not sales pressure. A well-placed story makes the cost of delay visceral and real.

"One company delayed fixing its onboarding process for another year. By the time they acted, they had lost several strong employees and had to restart hiring from scratch."

Lost Talent

Delays in process fixes lead to employee frustration and attrition.

Compounding Costs

Every month of inaction adds recruiting, training, and productivity costs.

Missed Momentum

Competitors who act first capture market share that is hard to reclaim.



AI Prompt: "Create a short story that helps a buyer understand the cost of delaying a decision."

Stories for Trust Building

Use Stories to Show You Understand

Trust grows when the buyer feels seen — not sold to. A trust story demonstrates that you have walked this path before with someone just like them.

Acknowledge Skepticism

Validate that their hesitation is reasonable and earned from past experience.

Start Small

Show that you are willing to prove value before asking for full commitment.

Earn the Expansion

Let results speak louder than promises — then grow the relationship naturally.



AI Prompt: "Create a trust-building story for a skeptical buyer who has been disappointed by vendors before."

"We worked with a client who was skeptical at first because they had tried similar services before. We started small, focused on one problem, and proved value before expanding."

Stories for Executive Buyers

Executives Want Business Impact

Executive-level stories must speak the language of the boardroom. Skip the features — lead with outcomes that move the needle on what matters most to leadership.



Growth

Revenue expansion and market share gains



Cost

Operational efficiency and waste elimination



Retention

Keeping top talent and loyal customers



Risk

Exposure reduction and compliance confidence



Speed

Faster time-to-value and decision velocity



Competitive Advantage

Differentiation that is hard to replicate



AI Prompt: "Create a 60-second executive-level story about improving client retention through better account management."

Stories for Product Demonstrations

Make the Demo Feel Relevant

Instead of showing every feature, connect each part of the demo to a real customer problem. A story-driven demo transforms a product tour into a moment of recognition.



Demo Story Example

"Here is where one client saw the biggest improvement. Before this, leads were falling through the cracks. This view helped managers see which opportunities needed attention — and act before it was too late."

The Story-Demo Formula

- Name the customer pain before showing the feature
- Show the feature as the resolution
- Quantify the outcome when possible



AI Prompt: "Turn this product demo into a story-based walkthrough focused on customer problems and outcomes."

Stories for Proposal Presentations

Help the Buyer See the Future

A proposal should not begin with your company — it should begin with the buyer's story. Structure your narrative to take them on a journey from where they are to where they could be.

1

Today

Where the client currently stands — their challenges, friction, and unmet needs

2

The Problem

The specific issue that must be solved and the cost of leaving it unaddressed

3

The Solution

Your recommended approach, grounded in their context and priorities

4

The Future

A vivid picture of what success looks like once the problem is solved



AI Prompt: "Create a proposal opening that tells the buyer's story before introducing our solution."

Stories for Closing

Closing Is About Confidence

A closing story helps the buyer feel safer about taking the next step. It reduces perceived risk by showing that others in similar situations moved forward — and it worked out.



"A client in a similar situation started with a small pilot. That gave them confidence, helped leadership see the value, and made the full rollout easier."

Reduce Risk

Start small to build internal confidence

Build Momentum

Early wins make full commitment easier

Earn Advocacy

Leadership buy-in follows visible results



AI Prompt: "Create 3 short closing stories that reduce risk and help a buyer feel comfortable taking the next step."

Interactive Role-Play

Practice Story Placement

The best way to master story-based selling is to practice in realistic scenarios. Use this exercise to sharpen your instincts for when and how to deploy a story.

The Scenario

A buyer says: *"We are interested, but this does not feel urgent right now."*

Your Task

Respond with a short story that creates urgency without applying pressure. The story should make the cost of waiting feel real — not manufactured.

Coaching Loop

After your response, review what worked, what felt forced, and how the story could be sharpened for greater impact.

 **AI Prompt:** "Act as a buyer who is interested but not urgent. Let me respond with a story, then coach me on how to improve it."

Evaluation Checkpoint

Choose the Right Story for the Moment

Knowing a story is not enough — knowing *when* to use it is the real skill. Match each sales moment with the story type that will resonate most powerfully.



Discovery Story

Opens conversations and surfaces hidden problems the buyer hasn't named yet.



Trust Story

Validates skepticism and demonstrates that you earn relationships, not assume them.



Objection Story

Dissolves resistance by letting the buyer reach the right conclusion on their own.



Urgency Story

Makes the cost of delay tangible without resorting to pressure tactics.



Executive Story

Speaks the language of growth, risk, and competitive advantage at the leadership level.



Closing Story

Builds confidence and reduces perceived risk so the buyer feels safe moving forward.



AI Prompt: "Given this sales situation, recommend the best type of story to use and explain why."



The 60-Second Sales Story

Keep It Short and Useful

Most sales stories should be concise, focused, and immediately relevant to the buyer's world. Less is more — every second counts.

30–60 Seconds

Short enough to hold attention, long enough to make an impact

One Problem

Focus on a single, specific challenge the buyer recognizes

Easy to Understand

Plain language, no jargon, no complexity

Buyer-Connected

Tied directly to the buyer's situation and priorities

 **AI Prompt:** "Shorten this sales story to 60 seconds while keeping the business impact clear."

Storytelling Mistakes to Avoid

Do Not Lose the Buyer

Even a great story can fall flat if it's delivered the wrong way. These are the most common traps that cost salespeople credibility and deals.

Talking Too Long

Rambling loses the buyer's attention before you reach the point.

Making Yourself the Hero

The customer must be the hero — not you, not your product.

Using Vague Outcomes

"Better results" means nothing. Specific outcomes build trust.

Telling Irrelevant Stories

A story from the wrong industry or role creates distance, not connection.

Sounding Scripted

Rehearsed delivery kills authenticity. Buyers can feel it immediately.

Overloading with Details

Too much information buries the message. Keep it clean and clear.

 **AI Prompt:** "Review this sales story and identify anything that sounds too long, vague, or self-focused."

Tone and Delivery

Sound Natural, Not Rehearsed

The words in your story matter — but how you deliver them matters just as much. Strong delivery builds trust before the buyer even processes the content.

→ Calm Pace

Slow down. Rushing signals nervousness and makes the story hard to follow.

→ Clear Language

Use simple, everyday words. Avoid industry jargon that creates distance.

→ Confident Tone

Speak with conviction. Confidence is contagious and reassuring to buyers.

→ Short Pauses

Let key moments breathe. Pauses give the buyer time to absorb the impact.

→ Buyer-Focused Phrasing

Frame everything around the buyer's world, not your product's features.

AI Prompt

"Rewrite this sales story so it sounds natural, conversational, and professional."

Remember

The goal is to sound like you're sharing a real experience with a colleague — not reading from a script.

Building a Story Library

Create Stories You Can Reuse

A story library is one of the most powerful tools a sales professional can build. Instead of crafting a new story for every conversation, you draw from a curated collection that's already proven to work.



Different Industries

Stories tailored to the specific sector your buyer operates in — manufacturing, finance, healthcare, and more.



Different Buyer Roles

A CFO cares about cost. A COO cares about efficiency. Match the story to the role.



Common Objections

Stories that neutralize the most frequent objections before they become deal-breakers.



Common Business Problems

Stories built around recurring pain points that appear across multiple buyers and contexts.



Different Sales Stages

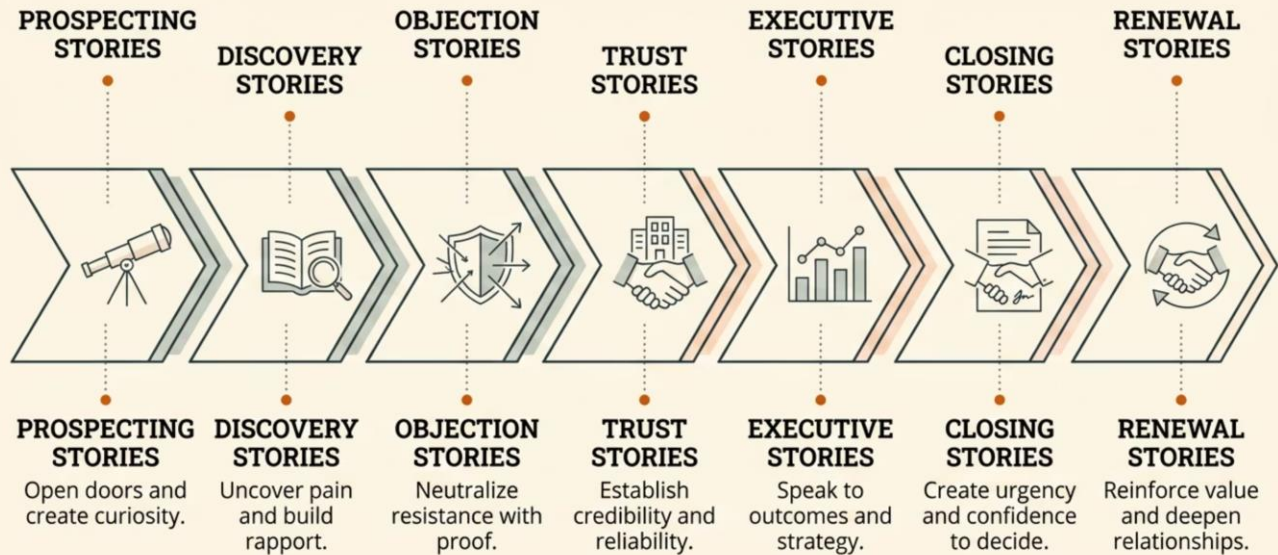
The right story at the right moment — from first contact to final close.

 **AI Prompt:** "Create a sales story library template with columns for buyer type, problem, story summary, result, and best time to use it."

Story Library Categories

Organize Stories by Sales Purpose

Not all stories serve the same purpose. A well-organized library maps each story to a specific moment in the sales journey — so you always have the right story ready at the right time.



AI Prompt: "Help me organize my customer success stories into sales categories."

Case Study: From Pitch to Story

See the Transformation in Action

BEFORE

The Generic Pitch

"Our platform improves communication and workflow efficiency."

This statement is vague, product-focused, and gives the buyer nothing to connect with. It could apply to any company selling any software.

AFTER

The Real Story

"One client had strong people, but messages were scattered across too many systems. We helped them create one clear workflow so managers could see what needed action and respond faster."

This version puts the customer at the center, names a real problem, and shows a tangible outcome.



Result: The story made the value easier to understand — and easier for the buyer to say yes to.

Interactive Exercise

Create Your 3 Core Sales Stories

Every sales professional needs at least three stories ready to deploy at any moment. Build one for each critical purpose below — and practice until they feel completely natural.

1

Prospecting Story

Opens a door. Creates curiosity. Makes the buyer want to learn more. Should be under 45 seconds and end with a question.

2

Objection Handling Story

Neutralizes resistance with a real example. Shows how another buyer had the same concern — and what happened when they moved forward anyway.

3

Closing Story

Creates confidence and urgency. Helps the buyer visualize the better future they'll achieve by making a decision now.

 **AI Prompt:** "Help me create 3 sales stories: one for prospecting, one for objection handling, and one for closing. Ask me for the missing details first."

Final Application Activity

Deliver Your Story

Choose one sales story from your library and practice delivering it out loud. Record yourself if possible. The goal is to sound natural, confident, and buyer-focused — not rehearsed.



Self-Check Before You Deliver

Under 60 Seconds?

Time yourself. Cut anything that doesn't serve the buyer.

Customer Is the Hero?

The story should be about their journey, not yours.

Problem Is Clear?

The buyer should immediately recognize the challenge.

Result Is Clear?

The outcome should be specific and believable.

Fits the Buyer's Situation?

Relevance is everything. Wrong story = lost trust.



AI Prompt: "Act as a sales coach. Listen to my story draft and give me feedback on clarity, length, trust, and business impact."

Final Evaluation

Storytelling Skills Assessment

To complete this program, participants must demonstrate mastery of sales storytelling by submitting three polished, ready-to-use stories — one for each critical stage of the sales process.

Stories to Submit

01

Discovery Story

Used to uncover pain and build early rapport with a new buyer.

02

Objection-Handling Story

Used to neutralize resistance and rebuild confidence in the solution.

03

Closing Story

Used to create urgency and help the buyer commit to a decision.

Evaluation Criteria

Criterion	What We Look For
Customer Situation	Clear, relatable context established quickly
Business Problem	Specific challenge the buyer recognizes
Solution Explanation	Simple, jargon-free, easy to follow
Business Outcome	Concrete, credible, and compelling result
Tone & Delivery	Natural, consultative, and confident

Final Takeaways

Storytelling That Sells



Build Trust

Stories create human connection that facts and features never can.



Explain Value

A story makes abstract benefits tangible and real for the buyer.



Reduce Resistance

The right story dissolves objections before they're even raised.



Create Urgency

Stories help buyers feel the cost of waiting and the reward of acting.



Hero Is the Buyer

Always position your customer as the protagonist of the story.



Confident Decisions

Great stories give buyers the clarity and confidence to say yes.

The best sales story is not about what you sell. It is about the **better future** your customer can achieve.